// AI BUILDER · FINDINGS

Closing the gap between what AI can do and what people actually need.

Evidence from published research on why AI projects stall and what people need from AI.

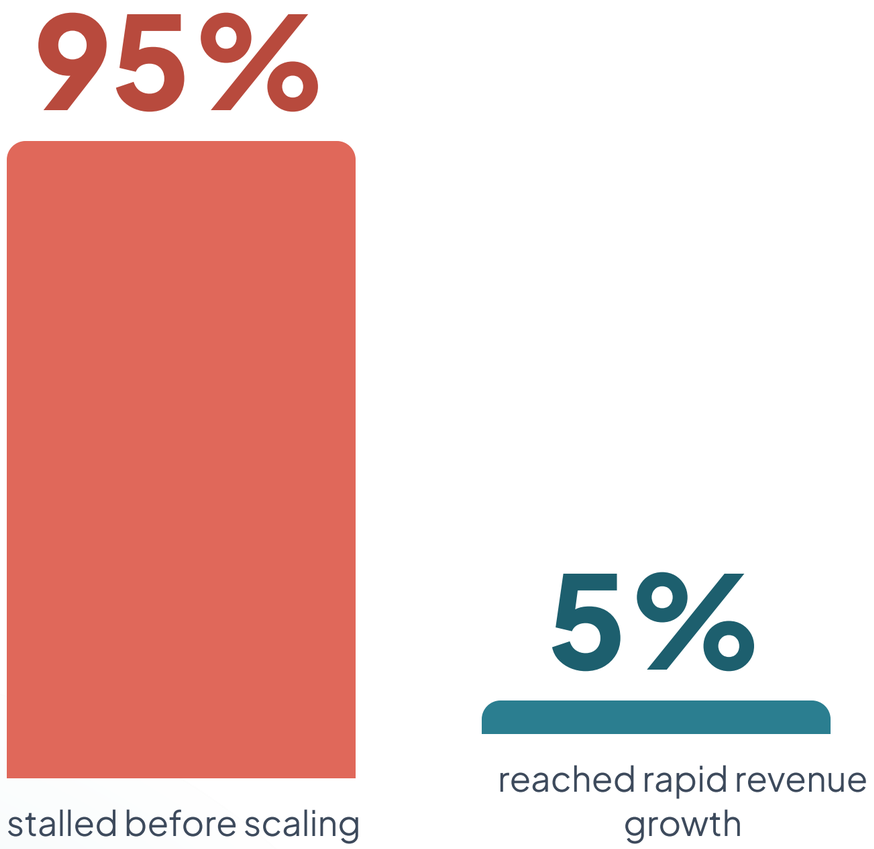
Yvonne Martinez
AI Technical Analyst · October 2026

// AGENDA

Six slides, one idea: build for what people need.

1. **The gap**
   Pilots stall on fit, not the model
2. **Trust**
   Few want AI with no human in the loop
3. **Human or automate**
   Workers split about equally
4. **The cost**
   2 hours a week checking AI work
5. **The signal**
   Readers could not tell the difference
6. **The takeaway**
   Fit, oversight and trust

95% of AI pilots stall, 19 to 1, and the cause is fit, not the model

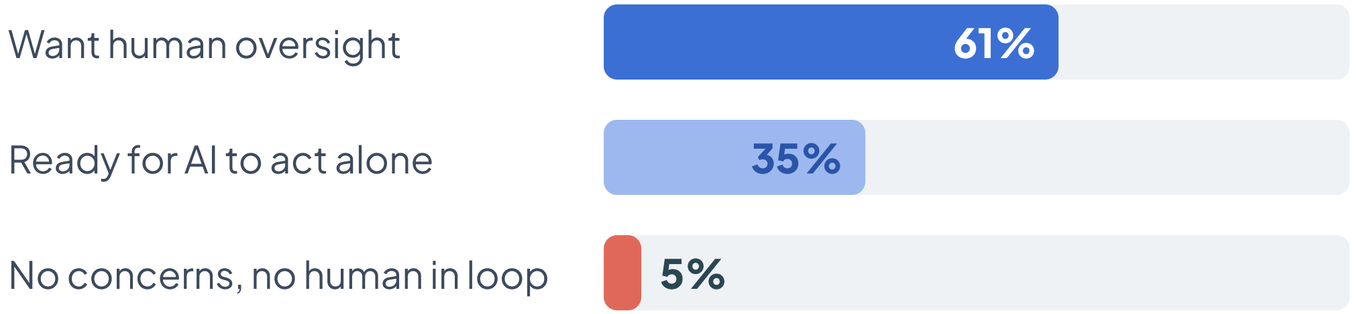


- 19 stalled pilots for every one that grew
- Cause: a learning gap in how tools are applied

MIT, GenAI Divide 2025, via Computing

// TRUST

Only 5% of workers have no concerns about AI without a human in the loop



12.2×

2,562 vs 210 of 4,200 workers

2 hrs

a week checking AI work, on average

TeamViewer and Sapio Research, 4,200 workers, 9 countries, 2026

// THE GAP

Workers want a human on more tasks than they want to automate

47.5%

want MORE human involvement
about 401 of 844 tasks

vs

46.1%

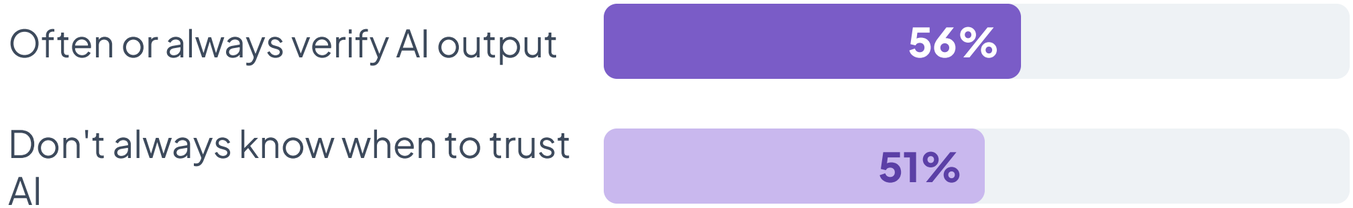
want AI to automate
about 389 of 844 tasks

41% of Y Combinator company-task pairings land in low-priority or red-light zones

Stanford SALT Lab, 1,500 workers, 104 occupations. About equal: the gap is small.

// THE COST

Workers spend 2 hours a week checking AI work, and 51% don't always know when to trust it



2 hrs
a week checking AI work, on average

2,352
of 4,200 workers often or always verify AI output

TeamViewer and Sapio Research, 4,200 workers, 9 countries, 2026

// THE SIGNAL

Readers could not tell AI-assisted writing from writing done alone

19
professional writers interviewed

+

30
readers surveyed

Personalized or not, readers could not tell AI-assisted work from solo writing. Small study: a signal, not proof.

Hwang et al., “It was 80% me, 20% AI” (arXiv 2411.13032, 2024)

// THE TAKEAWAY

The research points one way: build for fit, oversight and trust

Fit

Pilots stall on fit, not the model: 19 to 1

Oversight

61% want human oversight before AI acts

Trust

2 hours a week spent checking AI work

Build around what people need, keep a human in the loop, and make AI easy to trust.

MIT (via Computing); TeamViewer and Sapio Research, 2026. The takeaway is my reading of the evidence.